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Culture (OWC): [Chagga \(FN04\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1906-1926

Coverage Date: 1900-1926

Place Coverage: Chagga, Tanzania

Section Title(S): 4. Betrothal

One of the barrels brought to the bride's home is, as the name indicates /i.e. "Barrel for the Chieftain"—Analyst/ carried to the chieftain. It is a tribute to which he is entitled. In addition one barrel is sent to him directly from the home of the bridegroom.

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The capacity of the various barrels is so large that more than one man would be needed to carry one. Therefore all the young kinsmen are asked to help with the transportation: they fill the content of each barrel into pots which they carry to the bride's home where they pour the beer from the pots into the pre-arranged barrels.

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It is customary that the bride ask her younger sister to remove some of the beer surreptitiously from the first barrel while the men come and go to fill the barrel gradually. At the end, the men are surprised that some beer is missing. For this purpose the girl tries to get hold of a very large calabash and of several pots wherein she can hide the beer. This joke is a token of her love. If a girl does not comply with this custom she is expected to call off her engagement in the end. These barrels of beer are a proof that the bridegroom is absolutely sure of the virginity of his bride. If his informant has told him that the bride is not intact anymore, the bridegroom gives orders not to fill the barrels up to the rim. 96

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A few dracaena leaves are placed into the first barrel, hence the name of the beer. The beer is a menstruation magic, and it is probable that the dracaena leaves have a conjuring effect in this direction.

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The mngari and his assistant are the only representatives of the bridegroom's family at the ensuing beer feast. The other members of the suitor's family enjoy themselves with the left-over beer of which there is usually plenty.

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The bride's sib is fully assembled around the dracaena beer proper, and the bride's father asks his daughter to scoop up the first cup and to testify publicly that she is not a mbafu (a shameless one). Everybody knows and is delighted that she has preserved her virginity if the bride executes her father's command without trepidation and gives the first cup to her father, the second to the paternal brother, the third to her own brother.

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If the girl has lost her virginity without being pregnant, her father will give a hint to his son-in-law that he should lift her up (namire). The term refers to the girl's abduction on the way to or in the fields, a form which I shall discuss later on. If the loss of virginity is ascertained, the engagement is  81 as a rule called off only when the girl is pregnant by another man. If the bridegroom is the culprit, the girl is sent to his house without further ado.

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Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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